SAMPLE

The Tablet and the Pen: The First Records

Lawh and Qalam in the Quran

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Introduction

The Quran describes a register -- a book -- that exists in the presence of Allah, in which everything is written. Every event, every deed, every word, every moment of every life -- past, present, and future -- is recorded in this book. The Quran calls it the Preserved Tablet (*al-lawh al-mahfuz*), and it describes the instrument by which it was written: the Pen (*al-qalam*). Together, the Tablet and the Pen constitute the Quran's most profound teaching on the subject of divine knowledge and destiny -- the record of everything that is, was, and will be.

The concept of a divine book in which all things are written is one of the most distinctive features of the Quran's cosmology. The Quran does not present the universe as a chaotic, unmanaged collection of events. It presents it as a creation in which everything is known, recorded, and decreed. The Tablet is the record; the Pen is the instrument; and the writing is the decree. Nothing happens outside the writing. Nothing occurs that was not written. And yet -- and this is the Quran's great paradox -- the human being is accountable for what they choose, even though what they choose was already written.

This book is the sixth in the Unseen sub-series of the NurOne project. The first five books explored the angels, the jinn, Shaytan, revelation, and the soul. This book explores the Tablet and the Pen -- the instruments of divine decree, the registers of Allah's knowledge, and the framework within which the human being exercises free will. The Tablet and the Pen are not merely objects -- they are concepts that describe the relationship between Allah's knowledge and human choice, between the eternal record and the earthly experience.

The Tablet and the Pen are the foundations of the Islamic concept of *qadar* -- divine destiny. They represent the idea that the universe is not a random collection of events but a planned, recorded, and purposeful creation. Everything that happens was written before it happened, and everything that will happen is already in the record. This does not negate human choice -- it encompasses it. The human being chooses freely, and the choice was already known and written by the One who knows all.

The Quranic treatment of the Tablet and the Pen is brief but profound. The Quran mentions the Preserved Tablet explicitly in a few verses and alludes to it in many more. The Pen is mentioned once by name, in the opening of Surah Al-Qalam (68), and is alluded to in other passages. The brevity of the Quran's direct treatment is itself a teaching: the details of the divine record belong to Allah, and the believer is given enough to understand the principle but not enough to penetrate the mystery. The believer's task is not to decode the Tablet but to live in awareness of it -- knowing that every deed is written, every word is recorded, and every moment is part of a decree that was made before the moment occurred.

Chapter 1: The Preserved Tablet -- The Register of Allah

The Quran mentions the Preserved Tablet in several passages, each revealing a different dimension of its significance. The Tablet is not merely a book -- it is the master record of Allah, the source of all decrees, and the original of the Quran itself.

The Explicit Mention

The Quran states: "Rather, it is a glorious Quran, in a Register well-preserved. None touch it except the purified. It is a revelation from the Lord of the worlds" (56:77-80). And: "And indeed, it is in the Mother of the Book, in Our possession, exalted and wise" (43:4). And: "Rather, it is a glorious Quran in a Preserved Tablet" (85:21-22).

These three passages establish the key attributes of the Tablet. First, it is "preserved" (*mahfuz*) -- protected from corruption, alteration, and loss. The word *mahfuz* comes from a root meaning "to guard" or "to protect." The Tablet is not subject to the decay that affects everything in the created world. It is kept by Allah, and its contents are eternal. Second, it is the "Mother of the Book" (*umm al-kitab*) -- the original, the source, the archetype of all written revelation. The Quran, the Tawrat, the Injil, the Zabur -- all are derived from the Mother of the Book. Third, it is "exalted and wise" (*'aliyyun hakim*) -- elevated in status and filled with wisdom. The Tablet is not a passive record -- it is an active, authoritative document that contains the wisdom of Allah.

The Inaccessible Record

The Quran says of the Tablet: "None touch it except the purified" (56:79). The "purified" are the angels -- those who are free from sin, impurity, and worldly contamination. The Tablet is not accessible to human beings in their

earthly state. It exists in the unseen -- in the divine presence -- and only the angels, who are purified by their nature, can approach it. This inaccessibility is part of the Tablet's sanctity. The record of Allah is not for human eyes -- it is for the divine administration of the universe.

The Quran also says: "And indeed, it is in the Mother of the Book, in Our possession" (43:4). The phrase "in Our possession" (*ladayna*) emphasizes that the Tablet belongs to Allah. It is not a shared document, not a public record, not an open book. It is the private register of the Creator, and access to it is controlled by Him. The believer who understands this does not attempt to read the Tablet -- they trust that what is written in it is wise, just, and good, even when they cannot see the writing.

The Tablet and the Decree

The Quran connects the Tablet to the divine decree -- the predetermined plan of Allah for everything in the universe. The Quran says: "No disaster strikes upon the earth or among yourselves except that it is in a register before We bring it into being. Indeed, that is easy for Allah" (57:22). The "register" (*kitab*) is the Tablet -- the book in which every event is recorded before it occurs. Nothing happens by chance, nothing occurs outside the decree, and nothing surprises Allah. The Quran says: "So that you may not despair over what has eluded you nor exult over what He has given you" (57:23). The awareness of the decree -- that everything is written -- is the basis of the believer's emotional equilibrium. The believer does not despair over loss because the loss was written. The believer does not exult over gain because the gain was written. Both are part of the decree, and the believer's response to both is the same: gratitude and patience.

The Quran also says: "And everything they do is in written records. And every small and great thing is inscribed" (54:52-53). This passage, though it may refer to the recording angels' books rather than the Preserved Tablet, conveys the same principle: everything is written. The small and the great, the significant and the insignificant -- nothing is too small to be recorded, and nothing too great to be included. The comprehensiveness of the writing is the comprehensiveness of Allah's knowledge.

The Tablet and the Creation

The Quran connects the Tablet to the creation itself. The Quran says: "Indeed, your Lord is Allah, who created the heavens and the earth in six days and then established Himself above the Throne" (7:54). The creation followed a plan -- it was not random or improvised. The six days of creation were the execution of what was already written in the Tablet. The Quran says: "And He created everything and determined it with precise determination" (25:2). The word "determined" (*qaddarahu*) refers to the decree -- the precise, pre-written plan that governed the creation. Everything was measured, assigned, and written before it was brought into being.

The Quran also says: "And the sun runs toward its resting place. That is the determination of the Exalted in Might, the Knowing. And the moon -- We have determined for it phases, until it returns like an old dried stalk. Neither the sun nor the moon can overtake the other, nor does the night precede the day. Each swims in an orbit" (36:38-40). The movements of the sun and moon -- their orbits, their phases, their timing -- are "determined" (*qaddarnahu*). The word is the same root as *qadar* (decree). The celestial bodies follow a written path, and the path was inscribed in the Tablet before the bodies were created. The universe is not a free-form improvisation -- it is a performance of a score that was written before the instruments were made.

The Tablet and the Throne

The Quran places the Tablet in the context of Allah's sovereignty: "And indeed, it is in the Mother of the Book, in Our possession, exalted and wise" (43:4). The Tablet is "in Our possession" -- it is with Allah, in the divine presence. While the Quran does not describe the physical location of the Tablet, it is associated with the Throne -- the seat of Allah's authority over the universe. The Tablet is the administrative document of the Throne -- the record by which the universe is governed. The One who sits on the Throne is the One who wrote the Tablet, and the writing on the Tablet is the expression of His will.

The connection between the Tablet and the Throne also establishes the Tablet's authority. The decree on the Tablet is not a suggestion -- it is a command. The Quran says: "His command is only when He intends a thing, that He says to it: Be, and it is" (36:82). The word "Be" (*kun*) is the execution of the decree -- the moment the writing on the Tablet becomes reality in the created world. The Tablet contains the decree; the command "Be" brings it into existence. The writing precedes the creation, and the creation follows the writing. The Tablet is the blueprint; the universe is the building.

The Tablet and the Night of Decree

The Quran connects the Tablet to the Night of Decree (*Laylat al-Qadr*): "Indeed, We sent it down during the Night of Decree" (97:1). And: "Therein is made distinct every precise matter" (44:3-4 -- in the context of a blessed night). The Night of Decree is the night on which the decrees for the coming year are distributed from the Tablet to the angels who execute them. The Tablet contains the master record; the Night of Decree is the annual distribution; and the angels are the agents who carry the decrees into effect. The Tablet is not a static document -- it is the source from which the dynamic administration of the universe flows.